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GDR-023

Government Department of Records

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Department Historical Record

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Introduction

The Government Department of Records was established following the Second World War to provide a unified approach to the management, preservation and recovery of official government records.

Its original remit combined the standardisation of records management practices across government with the protection of records considered necessary for the continued operation of the state during periods of disruption or national emergency.

Over subsequent decades, the Department expanded into a national organisation responsible for defining records management standards, maintaining central and regional repositories (Sites), and supporting the recovery of official information throughout the United Kingdom.

This document records the principal events that resulted in enduring changes to the structure, responsibilities, systems or procedures of the Government Department of Records. Routine operational activity is excluded unless it produced a material departmental change.

Phase I - Foundation (1945 - 1955)

1945 - Post-War Records Continuity Committee

Event

Following the conclusion of the Second World War, a cross-departmental review examined the management and preservation of official government records.

Operational Impact

The review determined that existing practices were insufficient to ensure consistent preservation during national emergencies.

Large quantities of official records had been destroyed, misplaced or rendered inaccessible during wartime operations.

Procedural Outcome

The Committee recommended establishing a permanent department responsible for defining standards governing:

- Record Creation
- Classification
- Storage
- Indexing
- Preservation
- Recovery

Legacy

Recommendations formed the basis for creation of the Government Department of Records.

Documentation Changes

- COM-001 Post-War Records Continuity Committee Final Report (*New*)
- COM-002 Recommendations for the Establishment of a Government Department of Records (*New*)

1946 - Formation of the Government Department of Records

Event

Government Department of Records formally established.

Operational Impact

Common standards introduced across participating government departments.

Procedural Outcome

National policies published covering:

- Classification
- Archive Storage
- Box Numbering
- Retrieval Procedures
- Records Management

Legacy

Founding principles remain substantially unchanged throughout subsequent technological development.

Documentation Changes

- GDR-001 Department Charter (*New*)
- GDR-002 Department Operational Manual (*New*)
- GDR-003 Department Security Classification Manual (*New*)
- RM-001 Records Classification Standard (*New*)
- RM-002 National Archive Storage Standard (*New*)
- RM-003 Archive Reference Standard (*New*)

1950 - Regional Site Expansion

Event

Increasing archive volumes required geographically distributed storage.

Operational Impact

Regional GDR Sites established throughout the United Kingdom.

Responsibility for storage and retrieval distributed across multiple operational locations.

Procedural Outcome

All Sites adopted identical operational standards and reporting structures.

Legacy

Creation of the distributed Site network that continues to the present day.

Documentation Changes

- GDR-002 Department Operational Manual (*Rev. 2*)
- OPS-001 Regional Site Operating Procedures (*New*)
- RM-004 Regional Archive Transfer Procedure (*New*)

Phase II - Mechanisation (1956 - 1969)

1956 - Introduction of Microfilm Preservation

Event

Alternative preservation methods evaluated following rapid archive growth.

Operational Impact

Permanent records could be preserved while reducing handling of original documents.

Procedural Outcome

Microfilm adopted as the standard preservation format for long-term archival material.

Legacy

Established the principle that preservation media may change while archival content remains authoritative.

Documentation Changes

- RM-007 Microfilm Preservation Standard (*New*)
- OPS-005 Microfilm Handling Procedure (*New*)

1959 - National Archive Reference Standard

Event

Department-specific archive numbering systems replaced.

Operational Impact

Common numerical references introduced nationally.

Procedural Outcome

Unified archive reference standard implemented across all Sites.

Legacy

Reference numbering continues as the foundation of archive retrieval.

Documentation Changes

- RM-003 Archive Reference Standard (*Rev. 2*)
- RM-008 Archive Numbering Convention (*New*)

1961 - Mechanised Archive Indexing

Event

Punch-card indexing introduced.

Operational Impact

Record retrieval significantly improved.

Original documents remained paper based.

Procedural Outcome

Mechanised indexes established while preserving existing archive procedures.

Legacy

First separation between archive content and retrieval systems.

Documentation Changes

- SYS-001 National Archive Index (*New*)
- OPS-009 Punch Card Index Maintenance (*New*)

1962 - Archive Reference Incident

Event

During a routine Continuity of Government readiness audit, a classified document could not be located.

Given the prevailing international situation during the Cuban Missile Crisis, the affected Site entered immediate lockdown.

Following seventy-two hours of manual archive verification, the document was recovered from an incorrectly referenced archive box.

Subsequent investigation determined that the archive reference had been transposed during filing by a newly appointed clerk. The contributing factor was later recognised as undiagnosed dyslexia.

Operational Impact

No classified information was lost.

The incident demonstrated that human error represented a greater operational risk than equipment failure.

Procedural Outcome

Mandatory dual verification introduced for archive references.

Independent checking required before permanent storage.

Staff training revised.

Archive audit procedures expanded.

Legacy

Established the enduring departmental principle that:

Verification exists to protect the system from human error, not to demonstrate human infallibility.

Documentation Changes

- GDR-001 Department Charter (*Rev. 6*)
- GDR-014 Records Retention Policy (*Rev. 7*)
- RM-017 Archive Reference Verification Standard (*New*)
- RM-024 Archive Filing Procedure (*Rev. 2*)
- HR-006 Staff Induction Programme (*Rev. 3*)
- QA-003 Archive Audit Schedule (*Rev. 1*)

Phase III - Computerisation (1970 - 1989)

1973 - National Index Integration Programme

Event

Regional archive indexes were connected through a centrally managed mainframe computing system.

Operational Impact

Archive references could be searched nationally without altering the physical storage of records.

Information retrieval improved while preserving existing archive management procedures.

Procedural Outcome

National indexing standards were adopted across all Sites.

Regional systems became responsible for maintaining synchronised archive indexes.

Legacy

Established the principle that technological improvements should enhance archive retrieval without altering authoritative records.

Documentation Changes

- SPEC-001 National Archive Index Specification (*New*)
- OPS-009 National Index Synchronisation Procedure (*New*)
- RM-012 Archive Reference Access Standard (*Rev. 1*)

1984 - Departmental Microcomputer Programme

Event

Microcomputers were introduced throughout the Department for administrative and operational support.

Operational Impact

Routine administrative functions were increasingly computerised.

Archive preservation and verification procedures remained unchanged.

Procedural Outcome

Computer systems were adopted for operational support while physical archives continued to represent the authoritative departmental record.

Legacy

Established the separation between operational systems and archival information that continued throughout later digital programmes.

Documentation Changes

- IT-001 Departmental Microcomputer Standard *(New)*
- OPS-014 Computer Equipment Operating Procedure *(New)*
- HR-012 Computer Systems Training Programme *(New)*

Phase IV - Digital Integration (1990 - 2009)

1994 - Electronic Records Management Programme

Event

Electronic records management systems were introduced to support the increasing volume of digitally created government information.

Operational Impact

Digital records became subject to the same retention, classification and preservation requirements as physical archives.

Procedural Outcome

Departmental Records Management standards were expanded to incorporate electronic records while maintaining existing archival principles.

Legacy

Confirmed that records management principles remained independent of storage medium.

Documentation Changes

- RM-018 Electronic Records Management Standard (*New*)
- RM-019 Electronic Records Retention Schedule (*New*)
- OPS-021 Digital Records Administration Procedure (*New*)

2001 - Disaster Recovery Verification Programme

Event

The Department formally established the Disaster Recovery Verification (DRV) Programme to standardise reconstruction of archived departmental systems.

Operational Impact

Routine verification of archived systems became a national operational requirement.

Recovery capability could be demonstrated without affecting authoritative archive content.

Procedural Outcome

National Disaster Recovery Verification standards were published.

Routine verification schedules were introduced across all operational Sites.

Legacy

Established Disaster Recovery Verification as a core departmental responsibility alongside Records Management.

Documentation Changes

- DRV-001 Disaster Recovery Verification Specification (*New*)
- DRV-002 Recovery Environment Standard (*New*)
- OPS-026 Disaster Recovery Verification Schedule (*New*)
- QA-007 Disaster Recovery Audit Procedure (*New*)

2007 - Recovery Environment Standardisation

Event

Recovery environments used throughout the Department were standardised to ensure consistent reconstruction behaviour.

Operational Impact

Recovered departmental systems exhibited predictable behaviour regardless of recovery location.

Operational inconsistencies between Sites were significantly reduced.

Procedural Outcome

National recovery specifications were adopted for all Disaster Recovery Verification environments.

Legacy

Provided the technical foundation for subsequent Disaster Recovery Verification operations.

Documentation Changes

- DRV-002 Recovery Environment Standard (*Rev. 2*)
- SYS-011 Recovery Platform Specification (*New*)
- OPS-029 Recovery Environment Configuration Procedure (*New*)

Phase V - Continuity (2010 - Present)

2013 - Verification Media Review

Event

The Department completed a formal review of media used for Disaster Recovery Verification.

Alternative storage technologies were evaluated against existing operational procedures.

Operational Impact

No alternative medium demonstrated measurable operational benefit over the established verification process.

Existing verification procedures continued without interruption.

Procedural Outcome

Existing verification media were retained.

Departmental guidance reaffirmed that operational reliability takes precedence over technological replacement.

Legacy

Reinforced the departmental principle that established procedures should only be replaced where demonstrable operational improvement exists.

Documentation Changes

- GDR-001 Disaster Recovery Verification Specification (*Rev. 4*)
- OPS-015 Verification Schedule (*Rev. 5*)
- IT-034 Approved Media Verification Register (*Rev. 7*)

2021 - Recovery Environment Modernisation

Event

Recovery software was updated to maintain compatibility with contemporary computing platforms.

Operational Impact

Modern hardware could continue supporting established Disaster Recovery Verification procedures.

Existing verification processes remained unchanged.

Procedural Outcome

Recovery software components were modernised while preserving existing operational workflows.

No procedural amendments were required.

Legacy

Demonstrated the Department's continuing policy of modernising implementation while preserving operational principles.

Documentation Changes

- DRV-002 Recovery Environment Standard (*Rev. 3*)
- SYS-011 Recovery Platform Specification (*Rev. 2*)
- IT-018 Supported Recovery Software Baseline (*New*)

Closing Statement

Throughout its history, the Government Department of Records has adopted new technologies where operational benefit has been demonstrated.

The Department's fundamental principles of preservation, verification and recoverability have remained materially unchanged since its establishment.